

Brand authenticity: 25 Years of research

Jonatan Södergren 

Stockholm Business School, Stockholm University, Stockholm, Sweden

Correspondence

Jonatan Södergren, Stockholm Business School, Stockholm University, Stockholm, Sweden.
Email: jonatan.sodergren@sbs.su.se

Abstract

Twenty-five productive years have passed since the late Barbara Stern called for marketing scholars to take the topic of brand authenticity into consideration. Brand authenticity is now believed to be a core asset in mainstream marketing, yet confusion surrounds the nature and usage of the term. Using the Antecedents, Decisions and Outcomes format initially developed by Justin Paul and Gabriel Benito as an organizing framework, this article seeks to consolidate an area of thought characterized by multiplicity and excess of disparate meanings. Based on the extensive coverage of studies published over a period of 25 years between 1994 and 2019, extant literature on brand authenticity is reviewed. Three primary streams of research are identified: (1) characteristics that distinguish the 'real thing' from the fake, (2) the legitimizing function of authenticity and (3) emotional and moral aspects of authentication. Despite substantive contributions over the last 25 years, many areas of brand authenticity remain underexplored. By synthesizing extant literature, the aim of this study is to identify gaps in knowledge about brand authenticity and to prepare for a future research agenda guided by intersectionality.

KEYWORDS

ADO framework, brand authenticity, consumer research, marketing, systematic literature review

'The cult of authenticity pervades modern life' (Lowenthal, 1992, p. 184).

'In its polysemia this word, of course, like any meaning, must defer itself' (Derrida, 1982, p. 8).

1 | INTRODUCTION

In an age where consumers are bombarded with targeted advertising messages, when even our smartphones are thought to be eavesdropping on us, brands that convey authentic meaning gain the upper hand over their competitors. Brand authenticity positively influences trust

and loyalty (Portal et al., 2019), increases brand equity (Vredenburg et al., 2020) and adds value to the consumer experience (Goulding & Derbaix, 2019), thus allowing brands to 'turn a cacophony of content into a symphony of sales' (Adweek, 2019). Over the last 25 years, we have seen a steady increase in the discourse on what constitutes authenticity in consumption, not only through popular culture, media coverage and political debate but also through marketing praxis and scholarship. Brand authenticity is now believed to be a core asset in mainstream marketing (e.g., Frank, 1997; Gilmore & Pine, 2007; Potter, 2010), yet confusion surrounds the nature and usage of the term (Beverland, 2005). For instance, in the latest *Authentic 100* report (Cohn & Wolfe, 2017), Amazon, Disney and McDonald's are listed among the most authentic global brands, whereas other scholars perceive them

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as symptoms of modern capitalism, the very antithesis of authenticity (e.g., Baudrillard, 1983; Fjellman, 1992; Gable & Handler, 1996; Heath & Potter, 2005; Ritzer, 1996; Rose & Wood, 2005). What can account for such differences in the conception of brand authenticity in consumption and consumer culture?

Twenty-five years have passed since Stern's (1994) pioneering call for marketing scholars to take the topic of brand authenticity into consideration (see also Brown, 2015). Accordingly, the *fin-de-siècle* brought about an amplified focus on brand authenticity in marketing and consumer research scholarship (e.g., Arnould & Price, 2000; Goulding, 2000; Peñaloza, 2000). From iconic mainstream marketing strategies—from Coca-Cola's *It's the Real Thing* slogan, Porsche's *Roots in Racing, Not Posing* advertisement and Wrangler's *Born Authentic* tagline to Dove's *Real Beauty* campaign championing female empowerment, regardless of body size—it is apparent that the demand for authenticity or the 'real thing' now permeates many of our social institutions, including business administration (Beverland, 2009).

This endeavor aims to integrate the various research streams into one systematic whole, consolidating an area of thought characterized by multiplicity, many intersections and meeting points. A key purpose of this review is to identify the research trends in terms of theoretical approaches, research designs and publications. This is important because companies that demonstrate brand authenticity have justified faith in their products, enriching consumer perceptions of economic value (Hernandez-Fernandez & Lewis, 2019). Thus, the literature review spans 25 years of research. The findings help pave the way for further academic research by highlighting what we currently know and do not know about brand authenticity, outlining the three research streams of: (a) characteristics that distinguish the 'real thing' from the fake, (b) the legitimizing function of authenticity and (c) emotional and moral aspects of authentication. Furthermore, the Antecedents (perceived connection to past, brand virtuousness), Decisions (communication, commitment, coolness and connection) and Outcomes (brand trust, brand loyalty, perceived quality and cultural iconicity) (ADO) framework initially developed by Paul and Benito (2018) serves as a managerial implication as it may be used by policymakers as well as practitioners seeking to endow their market offerings with authenticity. The four C's in the decisions for brand authenticity mix (i.e., Communication, Commitment, Coolness and Connection) might be of particular use for marketing decision makers who wish to operationalize brand authenticity into their practice. Moreover, by exposing its logocentric and ethnocentric underpinnings, future research on brand authenticity is encouraged to follow the intersectional research paradigm (see Gopaldas & DeRoy, 2015), raising the question of who actually benefits from authentic brands in terms of consumer well-being and social conditions, in line with the agenda for transformative consumer research (Mick et al., 2012).

The article proceeds as follows. First, the cultural meaning of authenticity is discussed prior to specifying the concept of brand authenticity. Second, the methodology employed in this study is described. This is followed by a systematic overview of studies dealing with brand authenticity and the corresponding research streams, emphasizing the publication trends, theoretical frameworks and research designs. Next,

the comprehensive ADO framework (see Paul & Benito, 2018) used here to examine the different dimensions and characteristics of brand authenticity research is detailed. Subsequently, heeding the call for papers for this special issue, a significant part of this paper is dedicated to presenting avenues for future research in this area. In a concluding remark, the theoretical contributions and implications for marketing practice and transformative consumer research are briefly discussed.

2 | THE CULTURAL MEANING OF AUTHENTICITY

Derived from the Greek words *autos* ('self') and *hentes* ('doer', 'being'), *authentikos* implies someone acting on their own authority (Spiggle et al., 2012). Originating in the Romantic belief in a true intrinsic self, authenticity has been an ideal of western thought at least since the writings of Jean-Jacques Rousseau (Laermans, 2018). While the term initially indicated rejection of conformity and resistance to various forms of extrinsic motivations, the sense of the word as a synonym to genuineness or sincerity only entered the English language as late as the 18th century (Trilling, 1972). In other words, it would seem that the cultural meaning of authenticity has gradually shifted from the image of a rugged outlaw rebelling against society's laws and institutions, now also encapsulating values such as truthfulness, responsibility and transparency (Botterill, 2007; Giesler & Veresiu, 2014; cf. Holt & Thompson, 2004). For instance, echoing Arendt's (1967) exclamation on the death of truth in the political landscape, a recent special issue of the *Journal of Product & Brand Management* on the theme of brands and brand management under threat in an age of fake news has reinvigorated the logocentric tension between fact (as authentic, therefore privileged) and fiction (as fake, therefore inferior) in marketing and consumer research scholarship. However, 'lies have always been regarded as necessary and justifiable tools', Arendt (1967, p. 49) writes, not only for politicians and demagogues but also for brands and commercial actors. Herein lies the paradox of brand authenticity: The 20th century saw ideals of authenticity and personal autonomy being co-opted by powerful economic forces whereby the symbolic resource of brands have come to offer transformations so that self-actualizing consumers can enact their true selves (Heath & Potter, 2005; Thompson et al., 2013; also Thompson & Arsel, 2004). In a similar vein, Holt (2004) demonstrates how iconic brands exude authenticity by encompassing political and cultural authority as resources for self-expression, whereby consumers ultimately run the risk of feeling alienated from their aspirations and identity projects (Arnould & Thompson, 2005). From a cultural perspective, coming across as fake or artificial can indeed be damaging for many brands (Thompson & Arsel, 2004; Thompson et al., 2006).

2.1 | Brand authenticity

As Grayson and Martinec (2004) remind us, there is an important but subtle difference between being authentic and brand authenticity.

Authenticity is part of the ongoing search for meaning and belonging in life. As traditional sources of meaning in our culture such as family and religious institutions have lost their pull on younger consumers, they turn to consumer products and communities instead (e.g., Beverland, 2009; Muñiz & O'Guinn, 2001; Thompson & Coskuner-Balli, 2007; Wickström et al., 2020). Brand authenticity has been defined as 'the extent to which consumers perceive a brand to be faithful and true toward itself and its consumers, and to support consumers being true to themselves' (Morhart et al., 2015, p. 202). However, as it seems that brand authenticity is a polysemous and multilayered concept (see Akbar & Wymer, 2017), it might not be helpful to compress the wealth of disparate meanings associated with the concept into a single definition. The concept of brand authenticity has not fallen from the sky fully formed, and it is no more inscribed in marketing discourse. Hence, the purpose of this systematic literature review is to unpack the various perspectives on its meaning and significance for consumption. In particular, following a comprehensive format initially developed by Paul and Benito (2018), this framework-based review attempts to outline the ADO of brand authenticity as detailed in the next section.

3 | METHODOLOGY

Systematic review papers can be of several types (see Paul & Criado, 2020 for an overview). For the purpose of this study, a framework-based approach was employed with the rationale that thematic reviews with a framework are likely to show a more robust structure than, for example, structured reviews (Canabal & White, 2008; Kahiya, 2018; Paul & Feliciano-Cestero, 2020; Paul & Singh, 2017; Rosado-Serrano et al., 2018), bibliometric reviews (Goyal & Kumar, 2020; Randhawa et al., 2016), hybrid reviews (Bahoo et al., 2020; Dabić et al., 2020; Kumar et al., 2020; Paul et al., 2017), reviews aiming for theory development (Paul, 2019; Paul & Mas, 2020) as well as theory-based reviews (Gilal et al., 2019; Paul & Rosado-Serrano, 2019), method-based reviews (Sorescu et al., 2017) and meta analytical reviews (Barari et al., 2020; Knoll & Matthes, 2017; Rana & Paul, 2020). More precisely, the ADO format initially proposed by Paul and Benito (2018) is used as an organizing framework. This simple yet comprehensive framework is useful to extract the findings and insights, to highlight the research gaps and to provide directions for future research within the brand authenticity domain of consumer research in terms of: (a) Antecedents (i.e., the key attributes in brands that consumers associate with authenticity), (b) Decisions (i.e., the managerial strategies employed to project brand authenticity) and (c) Outcomes (i.e., the benefits of being perceived as an authentic brand).

There are numerous studies that cover the ADOs of brand authenticity. Thus, the iterative search and retrieval procedure started by developing a set of search concepts related to the brand authenticity scale (see Morhart et al., 2015), such as *brand trustworthiness*, *sincerity*, *brand heritage* and *consumers' self-authenticating acts*. The Academic Journal Guide published in 2018 (Chartered Association

of Business Schools, 2018) was then utilized as a point of departure. Besides being commonly used within business studies, Laurell and Söderman (2018) point out that this guide is based upon peer-review, editorial and expert judgements, following the evaluation of many hundreds of publications as well as being informed by statistical information relating to citation. Apart from marketing journals, the study was delimited to also include a few interdisciplinary journals such as the *Journal of Consumer Culture*, *Arts and the Market* and *Tourism Management*. The justification for this is that, for example, consumer culture, arts marketing and place branding are subfields of marketing and business studies where issues of authenticity are of particular importance. Hence, it would not be possible to fully account for the nuances of brand authenticity and its ADOs unless these perspectives were included. Moreover, as noted by Lucarelli and Berg (2011, p. 11), 'articles published in academic journals also assure a peer-reviewed quality, which is not the case with books and other non-academic material'.

It was impossible to include all 3,182 articles retrieved after the first key search. More precisely, the inclusion criterion was that the study had an explicit focus on brand authenticity. Hence, adopting abstracts and keywords as filters, those articles mentioning authenticity (and similar terms such as sincerity, integrity, social responsibility, brand trust, brand heritage, etc.), without actually studying them in relation to brand authenticity or commodity culture, were then excluded. In other words, those studies that merely touched upon the subject matter were excluded, for instance if brand authenticity was mentioned briefly in the abstract but the actual focus of the paper was on something else such as sales performance or product innovation. This could be a limitation as seemingly incongruous theoretical contexts could provide novel and unforeseen avenues for brand authenticity research.

In order to include as much literature as possible, references from the retained articles were also examined to identify additional sources. In total, 73 articles published during the years 1994 to 2019 were included in the review (see Figure 1). Each article was assessed using a systematic content analysis and developed coding protocol whereby a framework-based approach was employed (Paul & Benito, 2018; see also Paul & Criado, 2020).

4 | RESEARCH DOMAIN

Some of the most-cited studies on brand authenticity are summarized in Table 1. Overall, there were a number of theories from anthropology (e.g., Belk & Costa, 1998; Vann, 2006), cultural studies (e.g., Bryce et al., 2015; O'Neill et al., 2014), philosophy (e.g., Abolhasani et al., 2017; Fritz et al., 2017), psychology (e.g., Moulard et al., 2016; Newman & Dhar, 2014), aesthetics (e.g., Goulding, 2000; Södergren, 2019), art history (e.g., DeBerry-Spence & Izberk-Bilgin, 2019; Freathy & Thomas, 2015), communication studies (e.g., Dwivedi & McDonald, 2018; Schallehn et al., 2014), tourism studies (e.g., Chhabra et al., 2003; Cohen & Cohen, 2012), literary criticism (e.g., Rose & Wood, 2005; Stern, 1994), semiology

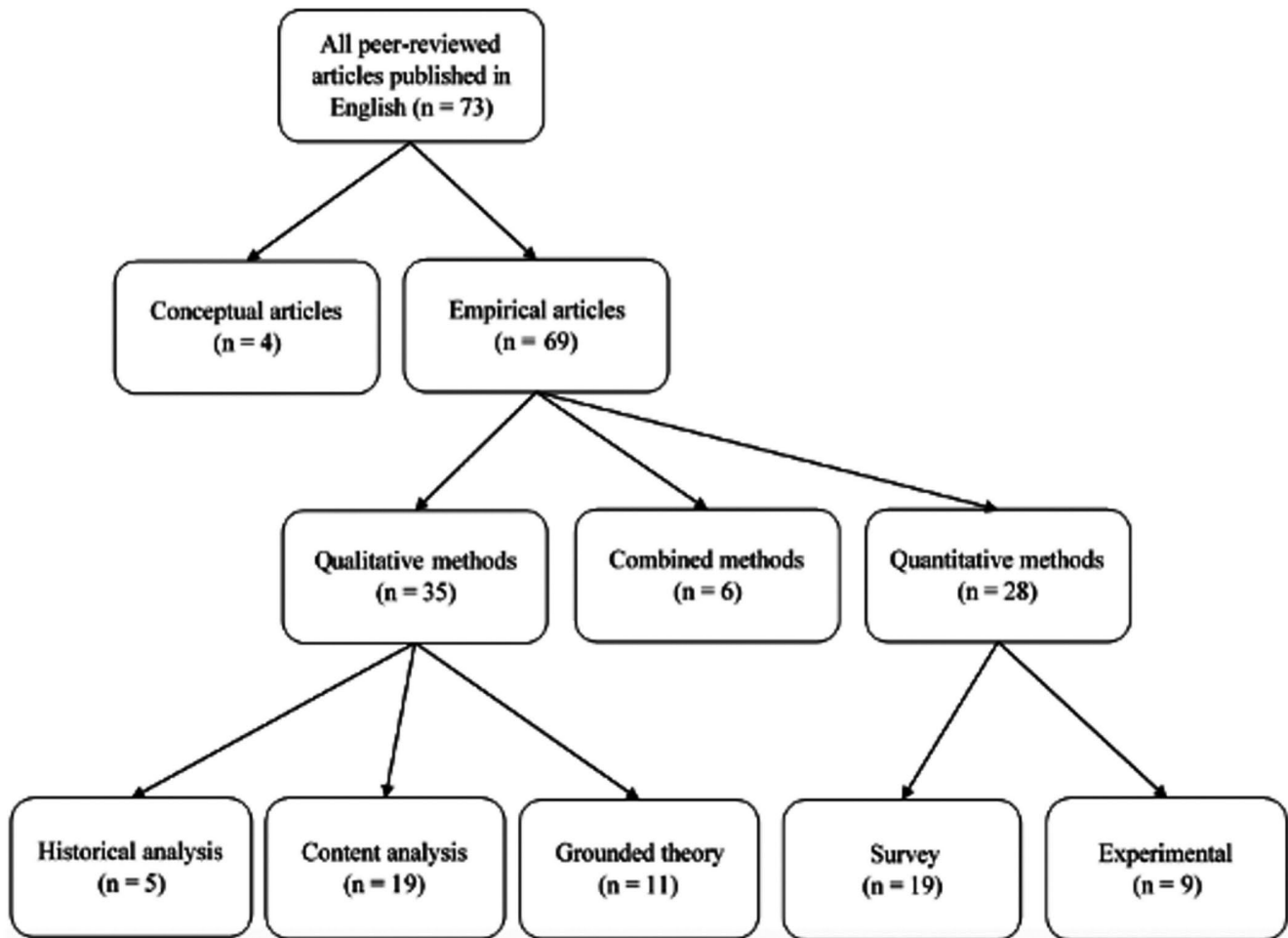


FIGURE 1 Overview of the final list of studies considered

(e.g., Ewing et al., 2012; Grayson & Martinec, 2004) and sociology (e.g., Alexander, 2009; Kozinets, 2002) that were applied to examine brand authenticity. Among those studies that implemented a positivist paradigm, the majority were either well-known theories within marketing and advertising literature (e.g., brand equity, emotional brand attachment) or social psychological theories (e.g., self-determination theory, attribution theory). Within those studies that adopted an interpretivist approach, a variety of theoretical foundations emerged. The majority employed a social constructionist paradigm or a critical theory approach rooted in postmodern deconstruction and/or consumer culture theory.

As detailed in Table 2, the articles included in this study were from 33 different academic journals. The *Journal of Consumer Research* ($n = 7$ [22.5%]) and the *European Journal of Marketing* ($n = 5$ [16%]) are those with the greatest incidence. A majority of the formative articles were published in the *Journal of Consumer Research* (JCR). For instance, in the 5 years between 2000 and 2004, half of the articles that dealt with authenticity ($n = 5$) were published in that publication outlet. Despite the fact that the research stream has increased drastically over the last decade (see Figure 2), however, the JCR has only published one article that explicitly deals with the theme of brand authenticity in the decade between 2010 and 2019.

Since 2015, *Consumption Markets & Culture*, the *European Journal of Marketing* and the *Journal of Consumer Culture* are those with the greatest incidence as they have published three articles each.

Research on authenticity can broadly be divided into three empirical contexts: (a) brands (e.g., Beverland, 2005; Brown et al., 2003; Leigh et al., 2006), (b) consumption (e.g., Belk & Costa, 1998; Beverland & Farrelly, 2010; Grayson & Martinec, 2004) and (c) advertising (e.g., Beverland et al., 2008; Botterill, 2007; Stern, 1994). Nonetheless, as noted by Becker et al. (2019), research examining authenticity in advertising remains sparse. The limited studies on this topic discuss authenticity in advertisements with regard to a specific aspect—such as the relationship between brand authenticity and an advertisement's persona or spokesperson (Stern, 1994)—or whether advertisements can reinforce brand authenticity claims by honoring brand heritage (Beverland et al., 2008). For instance, none of the reviewed articles studied whether it would ever be possible for a brand widely perceived as inauthentic to project authenticity through its advertising and marketing communications. In other words, if a brand is expected to lie, would it not be perceived as authentic or congruent with its core values if it indeed keeps on telling lies? For how long and to what extent can an inauthentic brand continue facing backlash and still thrive?

TABLE 1 The most-cited studies

	Author(s)	Total citations		Author(s)	Citations per year ^a
1	Holt (2002)	<i>n</i> = 2,742	1	Holt (2002)	<i>n</i> = 151.18
2	Brown et al. (2003)	<i>n</i> = 1,629	2	Brown et al. (2003)	<i>n</i> = 98.13
3	Kozinets (2002)	<i>n</i> = 1,627	3	Kozinets (2002)	<i>n</i> = 90.59
4	Grayson and Martinec (2004)	<i>n</i> = 1,057	4	Thompson et al. (2006)	<i>n</i> = 70.92
5	Chhabra et al. (2003)	<i>n</i> = 1,027	5	Beverland and Farrelly (2010)	<i>n</i> = 67.22
6	Thompson et al. (2006)	<i>n</i> = 987	6	Napoli et al. (2014)	<i>n</i> = 64.2
7	Belk and Costa (1998)	<i>n</i> = 867	7	Grayson and Martinec (2004)	<i>n</i> = 63.67
8	Beverland (2005)	<i>n</i> = 759	8	Chhabra et al. (2003)	<i>n</i> = 60
9	McIntosh and Prentice (1999)	<i>n</i> = 741	9	Morhart et al. (2015)	<i>n</i> = 58.25
10	Beverland and Farrelly (2010)	<i>n</i> = 682	10	Kolar and Zabkar (2010)	<i>n</i> = 52.33
11	Leigh et al. (2006)	<i>n</i> = 628	11	Beverland (2005)	<i>n</i> = 48.29
12	Peterson (2005)	<i>n</i> = 625	12	Leigh et al. (2006)	<i>n</i> = 44.31
13	Rose and Wood (2005)	<i>n</i> = 565	13	Peterson (2005)	<i>n</i> = 40.64
14	Beverland (2006)	<i>n</i> = 543	14	Cohen and Cohen (2012)	<i>n</i> = 38.86
15	Kolar and Zabkar (2010)	<i>n</i> = 539	15	Beverland (2006)	<i>n</i> = 37.23

^aCurrent year (2019) minus year of publishing.

Source: Google Scholar (06/08/2020).

The reviewed articles featured varied methods and research designs. The greatest number of articles (*n* = 35 [47.9%]) employed qualitative research methods ranging from historical and content analyses to ethnographic and phenomenological approaches. Quantitative research constituted 38.4% (*n* = 28) of the articles including both survey and experimental designs. The remaining articles (*n* = 10 [13.7%]) used some combination of methods, conceptual commentary, or analysis. Table 3 provides a detailed summary of the frequencies for each method and design. It is worth mentioning the relatively low number of conceptual articles on the topic of brand authenticity (*n* = 4), at least in comparison with the amount of empirical articles (*n* = 69), indicating a potential methodological contribution of this paper.

While some have tried to deconstruct the authentic–counterfeit dichotomy using postmodern theory, most scholars agree that authenticity today is a contrivance rather than a reality (Brown et al., 2003; Hietanen et al., 2020; Rose & Wood, 2005). Thus, the focus of many studies is on rendering authenticity by drawing on real and stylized cues (Beverland, 2005; cf. Gilmore & Pine, 2007). In total, three research streams emerged from the literature review, which together serve as the major theoretical contribution of this systematic literature review. The first research stream studied authenticity in more epistemological terms, focusing on the characteristics that distinguish the ‘real thing’ from the fake and constituted 54.8% (*n* = 40) of the reviewed articles. The second research stream focused on the negotiation of authenticity

in more sociological than epistemological terms. This research stream accounted for 30.1% (*n* = 22) and provided details on its social-historical and ideological patterning and the various discourses of power legitimizing the formation around authenticity in consumer culture. A third research stream focused on emotional and moral aspects of authentication and accounted for the remaining 15.1% (*n* = 11) of the reviewed articles. Studies in this stream focused more phenomenologically on the influence of lived experience and consumer imagination on the dynamics of authentication. Figure 3 summarizes the frequencies of each research stream.

The following sections briefly describe the primary objectives of each research stream as well as the findings that emerged to guide future managerial and academic applications and inquiry in terms of the ADO of brand authenticity (see Table 4 for a list of notable articles in each research stream).

4.1 | Stream 1. Characteristics that distinguish the ‘real thing’ from the fake

The first research stream studied brand authenticity in more epistemological terms. These studies tend to adhere to the broader ontological stream of determinism. If commoditized objects or experiences are staged, they can be deemed inauthentic even if the consumers

TABLE 2 Journals disseminating brand authenticity research

Journal	#	Articles
Journal of Consumer Research	7	Beverland and Farrelly (2010), Holt (2002), Kates (2004), Grayson and Martinec (2004), Belk and Costa (1998), Rose and Wood (2005), Kozinets (2002)
European Journal of Marketing	6	Dwivedi and McDonald (2018), Alexander (2009), Hede et al. (2014), Guèvremont and Grohmann (2016), Fritz et al. (2017), Goulding (2000)
Consumption Markets & Culture	4	Carroll and Wheaton (2019), Bardhi et al. (2010), Freathy and Thomas (2015), DeBerry-Spence and Izberk-Bilgin (2019)
Journal of Marketing	4	Thompson et al. (2006), Peñaloza (2000), Brown et al. (2003), Becker et al. (2019)
Journal of Brand Management	4	Gundlach and Neville (2012), Guèvremont and Grohmann (2018), Akbar and Wymer (2017), Ilicic and Webster (2014)
Journal of Business Research	4	Beverland (2006), Alhouti et al. (2016), Joo et al. (2019), Napoli et al. (2014)
Journal of Consumer Culture	4	Koontz Anthony and Joshi (2017), Michael (2015), Grauel (2016), Botterill (2007)
Tourism Management	4	Zhou et al. (2013), Castéran and Roederer (2013), Bryce et al. (2015), Kolar and Zabkar (2010)
Annals of Tourism Research	3	McIntosh and Prentice (1999), Cohen and Cohen (2012), Chhabra et al. (2003)
Journal of Consumer Behaviour	3	Ewing et al. (2012), Chronis and Hampton (2008), Muñoz et al. (2006)
Journal of Marketing Management	3	Napoli et al. (2016), Athwal and Harris (2018), Hartmann and Östberg (2013)
Journal of Product & Brand Management	3	Schallehn et al. (2014), Jian et al. (2019), Kowalczyk and Pounders (2016)
Journal of Management Studies	2	Beverland (2005), Peterson (2005)
Journal of Marketing Research	2	Newman and Dhar (2014), Spiggle et al. (2012)
Psychology & Marketing	2	Moulard et al. (2016), Ilicic and Webster (2014)
American Anthropologist	1	Vann (2006)
Arts and the Market	1	Södergren (2019)
European Journal for Sport and Society	1	Salome (2010)
European Journal of Cultural Studies	1	O'Neill et al. (2014)
International Journal of Business and Information	1	Liao and Ma (2009)
International Journal of Consumer Studies	1	Autio et al. (2013)
International Journal of Research in Marketing	1	Stern (1994)
Journal of Advertising	1	Beverland et al. (2008)
Journal of Consumer Marketing	1	Park et al. (2016)
Journal of Consumer Psychology	1	Morhart et al. (2015)
Journal of Hospitality & Tourism Research	1	Wang and Mattila (2015)
Journal of Product Innovation Management	1	Choi et al. (2015)
Journal of Strategic Marketing	1	Portal et al. (2019)
Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science	1	Leigh et al. (2006)
Journal of Travel Research	1	Chhabra (2005)
Management Science	1	Lehman et al. (2014)
Marketing Theory	1	Abolhasani et al. (2017)
Organization Science	1	Kovács et al. (2014)
Total	73	

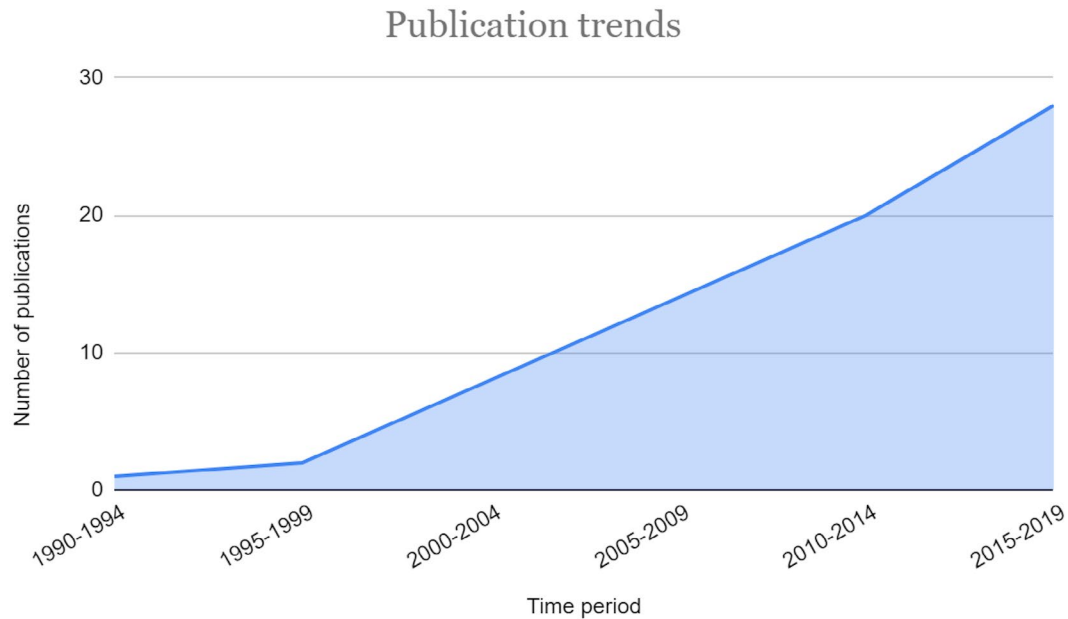


FIGURE 2 Publication trends by time period and year [Colour figure can be viewed at wileyonlinelibrary.com]

themselves perceive them as authentic (Boorstin, 1964). Hence, authenticity is derived from the object itself. From this perspective, there are 'museum-like' or 'art historian' criteria used to measure brand authenticity based on irrefutable sources, for example, 'this is an authentic Picasso painting' (Postrel, 2003). In other words, verifiable facts are used to restore the formation around authenticity whereby the true or genuine is, indeed, privileged over the simulacrum. Studies within this research stream often draw on Grayson and Martinec's (2004) distinction between indexical and iconic cues to authenticity. Whereas indexicality means that an object has an actual link to the original, iconicity indicates that the object can still be perceived as authentic by resembling the 'real thing' (Beverland, 2005). Some researchers now believe that there is a complex relationship between indexical and iconic elements that may actually influence one another (Kovács et al., 2014). For instance, as illustrated by Ewing et al. (2012), indexicality could manifest itself in certified organic seals whereby a corresponding iconic cue would be that the product merely looks organic through packaging. Thus, in this research stream, the objective is to identify certain types of cues that are more likely to receive authenticity attributions by consumers and/or to demonstrate that brand authenticity generates higher consumer value ratings of market experiences. Hence, contributions within this research stream are particularly useful for explicating strategic decisions (the D in the ADO framework) and processes for building and cultivating brand authenticity.

Among the studies that explored the *characteristics that distinguish the 'real thing' from the fake* ($n = 40$), a majority (77.5%) employed a positivist approach that focused on scale development and validation, while the remaining studies (22.5%) provided both ethnographic accounts and social anthropological perspectives to the assessment of brand authenticity based on, for example, representation of traditions, place of origin, craftsmanship, genuineness and connection to the past. In the latter category, reference is often made

TABLE 3 Widely used methods in brand authenticity studies

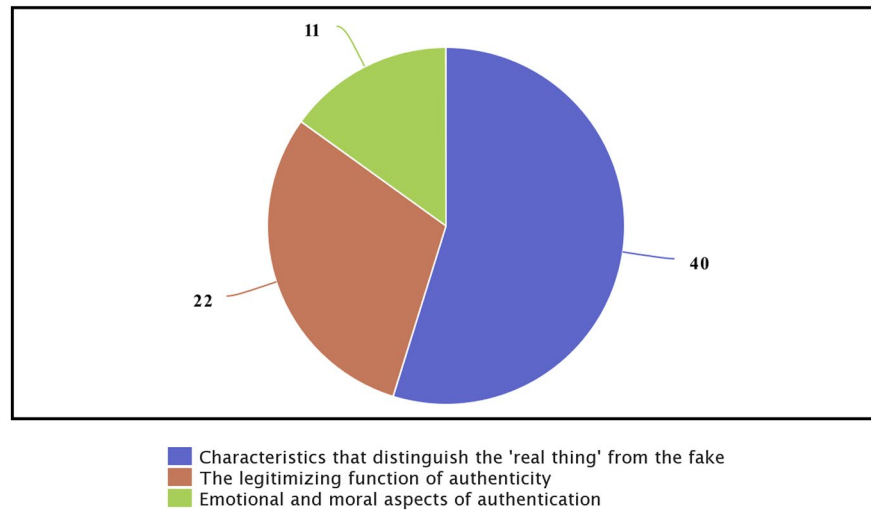
Method and design	No. of articles	Example
Qualitative (47.9%)		
Historical	5	Athwal and Harris (2018)
Content analysis	19	Rose and Wood (2005)
Grounded theory	11	Goulding (2000)
Quantitative (38.4%)		
Survey	19	Kolar and Zabkar (2010)
Experimental	9	Ewing et al. (2012)
Combined methods (8.2%)	6	Morhart et al. (2015)
Conceptual commentary or analysis (5.4%)	4	Peterson (2005)

to several influential works (e.g., Anderson, 1990; Lowenthal, 1992; Trilling, 1972). Specifically, Goffman's (1959) self-presentation theory, MacCannell's (1973) theoretization of staged authenticity and Peirce's (1998) semiotic emerged as predominant theoretical frameworks.

4.2 | Stream 2. The legitimizing function of authenticity

The second research stream studied brand authenticity in more sociological terms. These studies tend to adhere to the broader ontological stream of constructivism. As noted by Hartmann and Östberg (2013), authenticity is negotiable whereby its condition is the result of interpretations. Hence, brand authenticity is emergent and derived

Frequencies of each research stream

**FIGURE 3** Frequencies of each research stream [Colour figure can be viewed at [wileyonlinelibrary.com](https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/ijcs.12651)]**TABLE 4** List of notable articles per research stream

Research stream	Notable articles
Characteristics that distinguish the 'real thing' from the fake	Chhabra (2005), Spiggle et al. (2012), Alexander (2009), Grayson and Martinec (2004), Chhabra et al. (2003), Fritz et al. (2017), Castéran and Roederer (2013), Bryce et al. (2015), Kolar and Zabkar (2010), Beverland (2005, 2006), Muñoz et al. (2006), Schallehn et al. (2014), Newman and Dhar (2014), Zhou et al. (2013), Alhouti et al. (2016), Stern (1994), Napoli et al. (2014), Morhart et al. (2015), Beverland et al. (2008)
The legitimizing function of authenticity	Autio et al. (2013), Cohen and Cohen (2012), Goulding (2000), Peterson (2005), Thompson et al., (2006), Vann (2006), Peñaloza (2000), Brown et al. (2003), Holt (2002), Kates (2004); Leigh et al. (2006)
Emotional and moral aspects of authentication	Belk and Costa (1998), Bardhi et al. (2010), Chronis and Hampton (2008), Rose and Wood (2005), Kozinets (2002), McIntosh and Prentice (1999), Michael (2015), Beverland and Farrelly (2010)

from the community (Appadurai, 1988). From this perspective, issues of brand authenticity most often come into play when it is in doubt (Peterson, 2005). In contrast to the previous research stream that uses semiology to distinguish between indexical and iconic authenticity, this research stream is more interested in the legitimizing ideological and social-historical forces that allow icons to be endowed with indexicality (Cohen & Cohen, 2012). For instance, Södergren (2019) described authenticating acts as a citational practice mediated by authoritative performances in the context of costume dramas meant to re-enact historical epochs. Contrary to the experiential perspective, however, where there is no longer a need for the signified meaning of marketed commodities to have a real origin, the original could be seen as a referent to many signifieds rather than to one in particular. Thus, Kates (2004) elucidates how a brand can gain legitimacy among heterogeneous subcultures of consumption. In this research stream, the objective is often to examine how brand authenticity is employed to serve 'a propagandist role' (Freathy & Thomas, 2015, p. 190) in the pursuit of sociopolitical objectives and/or the cultural imperatives by which consumers engage in acts of authentication. Hence, contributions primarily serve the purpose of expanding our knowledge of outcomes (the O in the ADO framework) of brand authenticity.

Among the studies that elucidated *the legitimizing function of authenticity* ($n = 22$), the majority (95.5%) employed an interpretive approach that focused on social-historical or ideological aspects of authentication (Holt, 2002) or the way different behavioral types respond to various conflicts inherent in postmodern consumer culture (Goulding, 2000). Specifically, the 'Performativity Turn' is said to encapsulate the current research trend by which marketing scholars attempt to elucidate how consumer objects and social discourses often exist in dialog with experiences of state authenticity (Harwood & El-Manstrly, 2012). In this category, reference is often made to influential works in sociology and critical theory (e.g., Benjamin, 1969; Bourdieu, 1984; Horkheimer & Adorno, 1996; Weber, 1978).

4.3 | Stream 3. Emotional and moral aspects of authentication

The third research stream studied brand authenticity in more phenomenological terms. These studies tend to adhere to the broader ontological stream of existentialism. Wang (1999) introduced the term existential authenticity to denote a state of being when tourists at exotic locations

feel as if they reveal their true inner selves. Hence, authenticity is derived from the individual's subjective experience (Leigh et al., 2006). From the experiential perspective, brand authenticity does not revolve around the real origin of the brand's signified meaning but whether consumers feel as if they are in touch with themselves and the outside world (Arnould & Price, 2000). It has been suggested that this approach may have the most applicability when examining postmodern authenticity where signs are increasingly free-floating and self-referential (Reisinger & Steiner, 2006), injecting emotions into the consumption sociology (Holbrook & Hirschman, 1982; Illouz, 2009). For instance, Belk and Costa (1998) studied the formation of consumption enclaves around alternative realities and escapist fantasies. In this research stream, the objective is to analyze how consumers may enact imaginations as a response to increased levels of anxiety and alienation in society and/or to examine under what conditions consumers develop strong emotional attachment towards authentic brands. Hence, contributions in this research stream are particularly apt for elucidating antecedents (the A in the ADO framework) to brand authenticity, and how they appear in the consumer's life-world.

Among the studies that investigate *emotional and moral aspects of authentication* ($n = 11$), the majority (81.2%) employed an interpretivist approach focusing on consumer escapism, the alienation and contraptions of daily life in the city (Belk & Costa, 1998), or the way consumers may develop strong emotional brand attachment to brands they perceive as authentic (Guèvremont & Grohmann, 2016). In this category, reference is often made to phenomenology and postmodern theory (e.g., Baudrillard, 1983; Heidegger, 1962; Sartre, 1943; Taylor, 1991).

5 | THE ADO FRAMEWORK

Paul and Benito (2018) point out the importance of understanding how ADO dimensions are affiliated to each other. Thus, the linkages between the ADO dimensions can be as important as the dimensions themselves in terms of contributing novel knowledge. For instance, the managerial strategies employed to project brand authenticity (i.e., Decisions) is contingent on the key attributes in brands that consumers associate with authenticity (i.e., Antecedents), and driven by the benefits of being perceived as an authentic brand (i.e., Outcomes). Figure 4 summarizes the ADO dimensions that were derived from the literature.

5.1 | Antecedents

Fritz et al. (2017) suggest that antecedents to brand authenticity can be divided into two broad categories: (a) perceived connection to past and (b) brand virtuousness.

In terms of the perceived connection to the past, Moulard et al. (2016) add two antecedents related to rarity ('uniqueness' and 'scarcity') and two related to stability ('longevity' and 'consistency'). In addition to the categories suggested by Fritz et al. (2017), nostalgia and retro are said to be some of the ways in which consumers seek out authentic experiences (e.g., Belk & Costa, 1998; Brown et al., 2003). By going back in time to a simpler life, it is often thought that consumers can gratify emotional needs for connectedness and community

that are absent in present-day urbanization (Chhabra et al., 2003; Freathy & Thomas, 2015). In turn, Brown et al. (2003, p. 20) point out that craftsmanship encapsulates moral values that 'hark back to a time when the world seemed safer, more comprehensible, and much less commercial', whereby authenticity is often discursively mistaken for enchantment and pre-urbanization (Hartmann & Östberg, 2013).

In terms of brand virtuousness, Ilicic and Webster (2014) note that being real ('genuineness', 'sincerity' and 'trustworthiness') is an important driver of brand authenticity. Moreover, authentic brands are responsible, which means that they exude a sense of integrity (Holt, 2002; Morhart et al., 2015), avoid excessive exploitation (Spiggle et al., 2012) and engage in social commitment (Leigh et al., 2006). The latter is elaborated by Alhouthi et al. (2016) in the context of corporate social responsibility (CSR) where brand authenticity involves the following drivers: impact (i.e., whether or not the company is perceived to give enough, relative to its size and profits), perceived motive (i.e., if the CSR act is perceived to be driven by a genuine desire to help others instead of business performance or financial gain), reparation (i.e., the manner in which a brand is merely perceived as seeking to rectify a previous misdeed through CSR) and fit (i.e., when the action aligns with what the firm sells).

5.2 | Decisions

In turn, strategic decisions to cultivate and maintain brand authenticity revolve around what I would like to refer to as the four C's in the decisions for brand authenticity mix: (a) Communication, (b) Commitment, (c) Coolness and (d) Connection. For practitioners who wish to operationalize brand authenticity into their praxis, this section serves as the major managerial implication of this study.

In terms of the communication style, Fritz et al. (2017) demonstrate how those brands that emphasize heritage or tradition in their market communications are more likely to be interpreted as authentic, for instance by sticking to the roots or holding on to core values and founding activities. One may also wish to emphasize the relationship to place (Beverland, 2005, 2006; Gilmore & Pine, 2007) as Red Stripe (a beer brand owned by Heineken whose tagline *Born in Jamaica* not only downplays the scientific aspects of its brewing but also sticks to its Jamaican roots) and Tiger of Sweden (whose slogan *Designing Scandinavian craftsmanship since 1903* holds on to its core values and founding activities by highlighting its association with the aesthetics of Swedish minimalism). Moreover, Beverland (2006) points out the importance of appearing to stand above commercial considerations (also Abolhasani et al., 2017; Botterill, 2007; Koontz Anthony & Joshi, 2017), as well as stylistic consistency and congruence (e.g., Kowalczyk & Pounders, 2016; Schallehn et al., 2014) when communicating brand authenticity. For instance, football supporters all over the globe were furious in 2016 when it was rumored (as it turned out, entirely incorrectly) that the beloved lion was being axed from the new English Premier League logo. In 2000 British Petroleum spent \$200m in an attempt to bring 'green' authenticity to the global oil giant by rebranding its logotype; known thereafter simply as BP, the company adopted

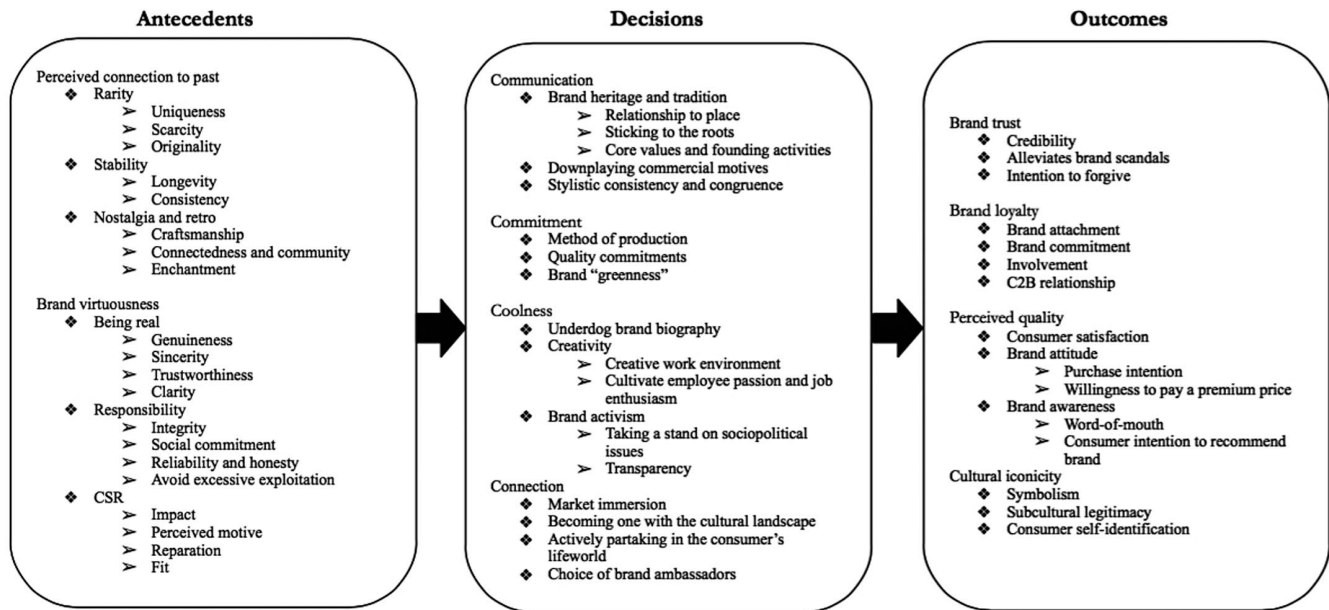


FIGURE 4 Conceptual ADO framework from Paul and Benito (2018)

the tagline 'Beyond Petroleum', which was met with considerable public skepticism (see, e.g., Balmer, 2010). Hence, when a brand innovates its production design or logotype, it is often regarded as less authentic whereby consumers look back in anger, yearning for the retro designs from days of yore (Brown et al., 2003). Further research is needed to understand the dynamic by which product design and innovation disrupts perceived brand authenticity.

In terms of commitment, the second C in the decisions for brand authenticity mix, brands can project authenticity by highlighting quality commitments in the method of production (Beverland, 2006; Ilicic & Webster, 2016). For instance, compare the copy written on the product designs of two competing Japanese beer brands: Asahi (*Asahi beer is brewed from quality ingredients using our pure cultured yeast and our advanced brewing techniques*) and Kirin Ichiban (*Brewing from only the First Press will ensure that the refined flavor is always at its purest*). Both brands emphasize the purity of their ingredients and the excellence of their brewing techniques as integral elements of their claim to authenticity. Consumers also tend to prefer organic or locally produced market offerings, whereby brand 'greenness' is of importance (e.g., Autio et al., 2013; Ewing et al., 2012; Jian et al., 2019). Hence, projecting brand authenticity includes accounting for what actually goes into the final product (Eggers et al., 2013) but also ensuring that the method of production stands out as a substantial quality commitment. Here, one of many points of intersection between the different ADO dimensions appear in the correlation between craftsmanship and commitment (specifically, the 'method of production' dimension).

The third C in the decisions for brand authenticity mix is coolness. More precisely, there is a correlation between brand authenticity and being cool, either on a niche or on a mass-market level (e.g., Warren et al., 2019). Brand managers may, for instance, adopt an underdog brand biography in which 'firms author a historical account

of their humble origins, lack of resources, and determined struggle against the odds' (Paharia et al., 2011, p. 775). Consider the story behind Ben & Jerry's, two friends who paid \$5 for a course in ice-cream making and then took on the giant Häagen-Dazs with their homemade ice cream (apparently, Häagen-Dazs even attempted to sabotage Ben & Jerry's business as it started to grow in popularity!).

Moreover, brand coolness is also related to creativity ('creative work environment' and 'cultivate employee passion and job enthusiasm'). Beverland (2009, p. 159) refers to this dimension of brand coolness as 'indoctrinat[ing] staff into the brand cult'. Consider, for instance, the late Steve Jobs, whose desire to see his staff develop and do their best is still considered a key component of Apple's brand DNA. Encouraging the staff to immerse in the values of the brand and/or the brand culture is often an incentive for innovation and high performance, which are considered the cores of creativity (Belk & Tumbat, 2005).

Brands are also increasingly expected to take a stand on sociopolitical issues. When brands match activist messaging and values with prosocial corporate practice, Vredenburg et al. (2020) note that they engage in authentic brand activism. However, despite Holt's (2002) paper being one of the most cited articles (see Table 1), the notion of inauthentic brand activism remains relatively underexplored in the brand authenticity domain of consumer research. For instance, how does brand activism intersect with perceived brand coolness?

In terms of the fourth and final C in the decisions for brand authenticity mix, brands can connect with the cultural landscape through market immersion, actively partaking in the consumer's life-world by choosing the right brand ambassadors. To sell products, firms need to stay relevant. However, excessive market testing might not be helpful at all because customers tend to be conservative and might not yet know what they want (e.g., Brown, 2007). Instead, authentic brands like Apple, Prada and Chanel are perceived to be at one with the cultural landscape (Holt, 2004). By being at one with the cultural

landscape, brands gain inspiration from their surroundings, which can inspire breakthrough innovations that would not have been possible through market testing (Beverland, 2009). Another way of connecting with the cultural landscape is to choose the right brand ambassadors. Consider, for instance, the brand Ideal of Sweden, which sells accessories such as phone cases. The cases themselves are relatively standard, but it was by closely collaborating with the social media influencer Bianca Ingrosso that Ideal managed to position itself as being at one with the cultural landscape (especially among the target group of young female consumers who use Instagram).

5.3 | Outcomes

Finally, authenticity is essential for creating brand value where the outcomes of brand authenticity that emerged from the literature include: (a) brand trust, (b) brand loyalty, (c) perceived quality and (d) cultural iconicity.

Ilicic and Webster (2014) demonstrate that brand authenticity increases brand attitudes and purchase intentions as well as brand trust and commitment towards the brand (see also Moulard et al., 2016; Portal et al., 2019). When a brand delivers what it promises, it is endowed with credibility which seems to correlate to brand trustworthiness (Erdem & Swait, 2004). Moreover, the brand trust (and credibility) outcome of brand authenticity is said to alleviate brand scandals and increase the intention to forgive (Guèvremont & Grohmann, 2018).

Next, extant literature suggests that brand authenticity positively affects brand loyalty ('brand attachment' and 'brand commitment'). Brand loyalty is represented by positive feelings towards a brand and dedication to purchase the same product or service repeatedly, regardless of a competitor's actions or changes in the environment and is, thus, correlated to involvement. As Choi et al. (2015, p. 240) point out, 'this also provides insight into developing holistic marketing strategies for product design or innovation by understanding the role of brand authenticity in building the consumer–brand relationship'.

The third outcome of brand authenticity that emerged from the literature was perceived quality (e.g., Kovács et al., 2014; Moulard et al., 2016). For instance, Moulard et al. (2016, p. 426) note that 'consumers are likely to rely on perceptions of a brand's authenticity in assessing the expected quality they will receive', thus proposing a positive and significant relationship between intrinsic motivation and perceived quality, specifically in artistic industries and hedonic contexts such as Michelin-starred restaurants. In turn, perceived quality positively affects consumer satisfaction, brand attitude ('purchase intention' and 'willingness to pay a premium price') and brand awareness as consumers are more likely to recommend the brand, for instance, by word of mouth (see Morhart et al., 2015).

Finally, authentic brands are imbued with cultural iconicity (see, e.g., Beverland, 2009; Holt, 2004). As Holt (2004:1) writes in the outline of his book on the principles of cultural branding:

People identify strongly with cultural icons and often rely on these symbols in their everyday lives. [...] More generally, cultural icons are exemplary symbols that people accept as a shorthand to represent important ideas.

Brands that are perceived as authentic are thus important in consumer identification as they become symbolic resources for self-expression (e.g., Holt, 2002; Morhart et al., 2015) and acquire subcultural legitimacy (e.g., Beverland et al., 2010; Kates, 2004). In total, extant research has primarily traced positive outcomes of brand authenticity (i.e., brand trust, brand loyalty, perceived quality and cultural iconicity), which warrants future research on possible negative aspects of authentication and the adverse effects of only associating authenticity with positive attributions.

6 | FUTURE RESEARCH AGENDA

This study presents a framework-based analysis of the current state of consumer research scholarship dedicated to brand authenticity. Through the in-depth review of 73 peer-reviewed articles, three primary streams of research were identified and designated: (a) *characteristics that distinguish the 'real thing' from the fake*, (b) *the legitimizing function of authenticity* and (c) *emotional and moral aspects of authentication*. Throughout all streams of research, it is clear that issues of authenticity continue to be inextricably linked to the market in various ways. There remains a clear need for future research that focuses on the nuanced sociopolitical and cultural processes through which consumption experiences are authenticated. Specifically, Cohen and Cohen (2012) note that, while the concept of brand authenticity has been widely discussed in consumer research, authentication as the social, political and cultural process by which brand authenticity is confirmed remains almost unexplored. Meanwhile, little research explores how consumers respond to different types of brand inauthenticity in commercial markets and popular culture (see Koontz Anthony & Joshi, 2017 for a notable exception).

To date, the majority of the research has focused on *characteristics that distinguish the 'real thing' from the fake*. Although such research is necessary, Beverland and Farrelly (2010) note that there are two major limitations in such studies. First, they result in a diversity of conceptualizations of brand authenticity (cf. Akbar & Wymer, 2017). This is problematic as it may result in an inconsistent body of literature, which ultimately prevents theory development (Stern et al., 2001). Failure to specify the conceptual meaning of brand authenticity can also be a cause of poor-quality research (MacKenzie, 2003). Second, this research stream is unable to account for unexpected results, such as consumer inclination to suspend disbelief (Chronis & Hampton, 2008; Stern, 1994). However, the identification of the *legitimizing function of authenticity* as well as *emotional and moral aspects of authentication* overcome those limitations.

In addition to the continuous crystallization of more generalizable frameworks of brand authenticity factors and attributes than

prior models that have emerged, specifically from the *characteristics that distinguish the 'real thing' from the fake* research stream (e.g., Bruhn et al., 2012; Morhart et al., 2015; Napoli et al., 2014; Schallehn et al., 2014), opportunities for further research also present themselves in better understanding the qualities of indexical vs. iconic cues; for instance, how different types of consumers may utilize the different cue types (Ewing et al., 2012) and/or confluence of indexical and iconic cues on different types of brands or different types of brand authenticity (Jian et al., 2019). More research is also needed to elucidate the playful, creative and potentially subversive ways in which consumers actively participate in acts of authentication (e.g., Athwal & Harris, 2018; Chronis & Hampton, 2008; Dwivedi & McDonald, 2018), especially in terms of taking ownership of brand stories and whether consumers evaluate brand authenticity congruently across hedonic and utilitarian product types (Ewing et al., 2012; Moulard et al., 2016). For instance, Guèvremont and Grohmann (2016) note that scholars have studied how hedonic categories allow consumers to connect to others through authentic brand consumption, whereas the potential of utilitarian product categories to do the same remains underexplored. In total, the reviewed articles suggest many possible avenues for future research, as detailed in Table 5.

6.1 | Antecedents

While there are many studies based on antecedents to brand authenticity in the ADO framework, there is a need for further elucidation, especially within the research stream of *emotional and moral aspects of authentication*, which is currently underrepresented in the discourse (15.1% of all retrieved articles). For instance, how can sentimental emotions such as nostalgia be said to enhance feelings of authenticity? While Brown et al. (2003) have shown us how retro brand meanings are predicated on a utopian communal element that is often taken as authentic, little scholarly attention has been given to the impact of nostalgia on brand authenticity.

Moreover, there is a need to further explicate potential trade-offs between various cues to authenticity. Hence, Beverland et al. (2008) call for future research on potential trade-offs between indexical and iconic cues in assessments of authenticity (see also Ewing et al., 2012; Kovács et al., 2014). Although different ADO dimensions might be more or less prone to produce perceptions of brand authenticity as a synergy effect, it would be interesting to see how the different dimensions interact and co-operate in different constellations. For instance, how do the different antecedents ('perceived connection to past' and 'brand virtuousness') correspond to the four C's in the decisions for brand authenticity mix? Is the perceived connection to the past as important as brand virtuousness in connecting with the cultural landscape? Does it change across product categories, cultural contexts and social systems?

Further research is also needed to address how consumers negotiate tensions between taste-schemes, moral motivations and actual behavior. For instance, it would seem that the quest for authenticity is embedded in a web of other everyday practices which are 'competitors

for time and other resources' (Grauel, 2016, p. 866). Hence, consumers might be willing to compromise their authenticity where external circumstances could be used as motives for legitimizing their consumer behavior. Following Beverland and Farrelly (2010), consumers are motivated to focus on specific goals when making assessments of authenticity. Consumption can, for instance, be driven by social responsibility (e.g., environmental care, buying locally produced food), inspiration (e.g., desire to be in touch with one's inner self, express one's own creativity), or utilitarian needs (e.g., keeping one's home neat and tidy, spending money on domestic products). It would thus be interesting to study how conflicts between such 'regimes of justification' (see Boltanski & Thévenot, 2006) may affect how groups and individuals authenticate consumer choices, objects and experiences at different stages throughout their lifespan (also Goulding, 2000). To link back to the introductory discussion on the philosophical underpinnings of the authenticity concept in light of the obsession with authenticity in contemporary consumer culture, this would go against the Rousseauian ideal of a true inner self, indicating that individuals are dynamic and rise up against the backdrop of structural change and personal development (e.g., Askegaard & Linnet, 2011).

6.2 | Decisions

For the D in the ADO framework, Berthon et al. (2008) note that extant research has focused almost exclusively on large multinational brands. Hence, Eggers et al. (2013) argue that there is an inadequate understanding of brand authenticity in small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs). Specifically, there is a need to advance our understanding of the impact of brand authenticity on SME growth, as well as how strategic decisions to build and cultivate brand authenticity may vary across different types of enterprises. Furthermore, extant literature has predominantly focused on niche brands and luxury consumption. Research based on markets with low-involvement, mass-marketed products is clearly warranted (e.g., Autio et al., 2013; cf. Beverland, 2006; Dwivedi & McDonald, 2018). Future research may, for instance, want to take into consideration other mass-market products that are less likely to be associated with connotations of heritage and pedigree, where care should be given to the degree to which consumers are willing to assimilate and act on messages related to authenticity and its antecedents.

It would also be interesting to study the impact of social media and influencer marketing decisions on perception of brand authenticity. Influencer-produced branded content is generally considered to have more organic contact with potential consumers than brand-generated advertisements (Södergren & Vallström, 2020), whereby some scholars argue that social media can also contribute to social change (e.g., Audrezet et al., 2018; Kozinets et al., 2012). Similarly, what would be the possible risks of collaborating with social media influencers (and other types of brand ambassadors) should they get caught up in a scandal or some other controversial situation? For instance, to what extent are consumers able to forgive a brand that is associated with celebrities who were accused of sexual misconduct during the #MeToo movement? This would correspond with Guèvremont and Grohmann's

TABLE 5 Proposed topics for future research

Thematic area	Proposed topic
Scales/theories/models/frameworks	Continuous crystallization of more generalizable frameworks of brand authenticity factors and attributes (e.g., Napoli et al., 2014)
	A framework for various types of brand inauthenticity (e.g., Koontz Anthony & Joshi, 2017)
	The shifting focus from brand authenticity to consumer acts of authentication (e.g., Cohen & Cohen, 2012)
	Whether it would be possible for a brand widely perceived as inauthentic to project authenticity through its advertising and marketing communications (e.g., Becker et al., 2019)
	If consumers evaluate brand authenticity congruently across hedonic and utilitarian product types (e.g., Guèvremont & Grohmann, 2016)
Antecedents to brand authenticity	Potential trade-offs between indexical and iconic cues in assessments of brand authenticity (e.g., Beverland et al., 2008)
	How different types of consumers utilize the different cue types (e.g., Beverland & Farrelly, 2010)
	Consumer creativity and play as potential antecedents to brand authenticity (e.g., Chronis et al., 2012)
	Links between nostalgia and brand authenticity (e.g., Fritz et al., 2017)
Strategic decisions for building and cultivating brand authenticity	The intricate ways by which the quest for authenticity is embedded in a web of everyday practices (e.g., Grauel, 2016)
	How product design and innovation disrupt the perceived brand authenticity (e.g., Balmer, 2010)
	Specify the impact of brand authenticity on SME growth (e.g., Eggers et al., 2013)
	Do the decisions needed to build brand authenticity differ across various types of enterprises? (e.g., Eggers et al., 2013)
	How brand authenticity is derived from markets with low-involvement, mass-marketed products (e.g., Dwivedi & McDonald, 2018)
Outcomes of brand authentication	Possible impact of influencer marketing decisions on perception of brand authenticity (e.g., Södergren & Vallström, 2020)
	The various ways by which brands can manage authenticity internally within the organization (e.g., Beverland, 2009)
	To what extent can brands be perceived as too sincere? (e.g., Becker et al., 2019)
	What are the potential negative outcomes of brand authentication? (e.g., Illicic & Webster, 2014)
Recommendations	Explicate the subtle distinction between brand authenticity and brand trust (e.g., Portal et al., 2019)
	Broaden our understanding of brand heritage in regards to emotional attachment and its role in consumer decision making (e.g., Ballantyne et al., 2006)
	Further elaboration of CSR authenticity and how consumers make judgement regarding CSR investments (e.g., Alhouthi et al., 2016)
	How the role of honesty differs from reliability in the construction of CSR authenticity (e.g., Joo et al., 2019)
	How the perceived brand authenticity might be affected by exploitative marketing strategies such as woke-washing (and other forms of 'washing') (e.g., Vredenburg et al., 2020)
	How does brand authenticity relate to issues of cultural appropriation (Abolhasani et al., 2017)
	Broaden the sampling procedure beyond the customary frame of western consumers (e.g., Vann, 2006)

(2018) call for further research to study the alleviating effect of brand authenticity in scandals. Furthermore, previous research has studied how brands project authenticity through their marketing communications, but little is known about how brands can manage authenticity internally within the organization through the cultivation of a creative work environment (Beverland, 2009).

6.3 | Outcomes

The overview suggests that extant literature primarily focuses on positive outcomes of authentication. Hence, Hartmann and

Östberg (2013) note how authenticity is often discursively mistaken for enchantment, even though the two terms are conceptually distinct. Bardhi et al. (2010) demonstrate that authenticity or the 'real thing' can also be experienced as negative, not least in the market of terroir and regional cuisine. Similarly, Becker et al. (2019) question the extent to which brands can be perceived as too honest and sincere (see also Sundar & Noseworthy, 2016). It would be interesting to see more research exploring possible negative aspects of brand authentication. If authenticity, as suggested by Freathy and Thomas (2015, p. 190), serves 'a propagandist role' to legitimize dominant sociopolitical meaning and ideology—for example, by making hegemonic economic forces seem natural or masking different types

of oppression—one may also wish to consider the price we have to pay for collectively making other ways of organizing social life seem inauthentic. For instance, who are the victims of these exclusions? On a slightly different note, Portal et al. (2019) recommend future research to explicate the subtle distinction between brand authenticity and the construct of brand trust, which, following the ADO framework proposed in this study, is one of the outcomes of brand authenticity. Under which circumstances would it be possible for consumers to either trust a brand they perceive as inauthentic or authenticate a brand they perceive as untrustworthy?

By proposing some key factors to succeed in today's oversaturated and competitive marketplace, Ballantyne et al. (2006) demonstrate that those brands whose image signifies facets of heritage and authenticity are more likely to develop an emotional and symbolic attachment with consumers. Thus, there is a need for continuous efforts to broaden our understanding of brand authenticity and brand heritage in regards to emotional brand attachment. Moreover, while findings by Guèvremont and Grohmann (2018) indicate that consumers respond more favorably to authentic than to inauthentic brands in the event of a scandal, even brands that are perceived as authentic are harmed by a brand scandal. Hence, there is a need to further elucidate the protective effects of brand authenticity (i.e., the 'intention to forgive' dimension of the ADO framework).

6.4 | Further recommendations

Beyond the issues noted above, several other recommendations for future research emerge from the review. First, there is a need to better understand the role of authenticity in the context of CSR and brand activism (e.g., Alhouthi et al., 2016; Holt, 2002; Vredenburg et al., 2020). As noted by Fritz et al. (2017), additional research is needed to specify the effect of brand social commitment on perception of brand authenticity. Following Alhouthi et al. (2016), there is an opportunity for future research to explore the complex process by which consumers form judgments about the corporate motives behind CSR investments. Moreover, Joo et al. (2019) suggest that future research may want to explore the role of honesty more explicitly in CSR authenticity and how it differs from reliability. For instance, there are few studies to date on how perception of brand authenticity might be affected by different types of exploitative marketing strategies—such as 'woke-washing' (or other forms of 'washing')—where products are promoted to appeal to consumer consciousness to be perceived as progressive and tolerant, without actually standing for or integrating these values into the brand's core values (Vredenburg et al., 2020). Thus, Abolhasani et al. (2017) suggest that public policymakers could prohibit sacred products (e.g., music, traditions and cultural artifacts) from appearing in commercial advertising or political campaigns in the spirit of cultural appropriation. But how exactly does brand authenticity relate to issues of cultural appropriation?

As a final remark, in terms of sampling procedure, past research seldom examines consumers beyond the customary frame of 'affluent, white, Anglo-Saxons of European descent' (Burton, 2009:184). While

Vann (2006) studied the limits of authenticity in Vietnamese consumer markets, DeBerry-Spence and Izberk-Bilgin (2019, p. 4) note that 'existing research fails to capture the nuances of consumer authentication in the face of ideological and historical forces that render consumer identity ambiguous, disputed, and even stigmatized'. In doing so, Bryce et al. (2015) suggest that the prevailing ethnocentric perceptions in the literature needs to be challenged and I agree that this is one of the most pressing issues to take into consideration for a future research agenda.

7 | IMPLICATIONS FOR MARKETING RESEARCH

This systematic literature review has presented an ADO framework-based analysis of the current state of marketing and consumer research scholarship dedicated to brand authenticity. Through the in-depth review of 73 peer-reviewed articles, the major theoretical contribution includes the identification and designation of three primary streams of research: (a) *characteristics that distinguish the 'real thing' from the fake*, (b) *the legitimizing function of authenticity* and (c) *emotional and moral aspects of authentication*. Contrary to the set of designations proposed by Morhart et al. (2015) and many other scholars based on ontological perspectives (i.e., objective, constructive and existential), the designations suggested in this paper are more suitable to identify and describe the primary objectives of each research stream (i.e., to identify certain types of cues that are more likely to receive authenticity attributions by consumers and/or to demonstrate that brand authenticity generates higher consumer value ratings of market experiences; to examine how brand authenticity is employed to serve 'a propagandist role' in the pursuit of sociopolitical objectives and/or the cultural imperatives by which consumers engage in acts of authentication; and to analyze how consumers may enact imaginations as a response to increased levels of anxiety and alienation in society and/or to examine under what conditions consumers develop strong emotional attachment towards authentic brands).

7.1 | Implications for marketing practice

Throughout all streams of research, it is clear that issues of authenticity continue to be inextricably linked to the market in various ways. The ADO framework presented by Paul and Benito (2018) and further elaborated here is a useful tool to organize analyses of brand authenticity in different market contexts based on Antecedents (perceived connection to past, brand virtuousness), Decisions (communication, commitment, coolness and connection) and Outcomes (brand trust, brand loyalty, perceived quality and cultural iconicity). Specifically, for marketing decision makers who wish to operationalize brand authenticity into their practice, the four C's of the decisions for brand authenticity mix serve as the major managerial contribution of this study. It is also worth emphasizing that each research stream has its own strengths and weaknesses in terms of elucidating different aspects of the ADO framework presented here.

7.2 | Concluding remarks and implications for transformative consumer research

Through this critical review, I show that there has been a significant increase in scholarly interest and research publications on brand authenticity over the last 25 years. Challenging marketers and researchers to broaden their conception of brand authenticity to become more inclusive, the following propositions are suggested.

1. Brand authenticity is a dynamic concept often transpiring any dichotomization of the literal versus the figurative, yet extant literature tends to overemphasize the notion of authenticity as synonymous to being 'genuine, real, and/or true' (Beverland & Farrelly, 2010, p. 839).
2. Brand authenticity is a broad sociocultural category that few people think of in the same way, yet much of the academic work has tended to privilege a logocentric and/or ethnocentric view where certain connotations that are positively attributed from a western perspective are taken as the only way to perceive brand authenticity.
3. Consumers are colored by sensibilities (e.g., hedonic and aesthetic aspects) as much as intelligibility (e.g., utilitarian aspects) when they make assessments of brand authenticity and/or engage in self-authenticating acts (see also Holbrook & Hirschman, 1982).

Returning to the three propositions, the different research streams are useful to highlight how brand authenticity can be a paradoxical and dynamic concept. For instance, clarity may be a characteristic that distinguishes the 'real thing' from the fake whereas ambiguity enhances consumer emotions and moral aspects of authentication. Counterintuitively, clarity, and ambiguity could thus simultaneously be seen as authenticating elements (see Brown et al., 2013). It would be interesting to study how clarity vis-à-vis ambiguity drives different types of brand authenticity (e.g., 'green' brand authenticity, brand extension authenticity, subcultural authenticity, etc.). For instance, it is likely that ambiguity is more favorable for brands whose claim to authenticity lies in its cultural iconicity ('symbolism' and 'subcultural legitimacy'), whereas clarity is more important in the construction of CSR authenticity and/or brand activism. In those terms, Jian et al. (2019) call for more research studying the confluence of iconic and indexical elements—such as cultural symbolism and actual behavior—on different types of brands and different types of brand authenticity from a cross-cultural perspective.

Moreover, the literature on brand authenticity has been prone to a certain logocentrism where clarity is often privileged over ambiguity. But what would be the potential negative outcomes of brand authenticity and authentication, assuming that clarity is privileged over ambiguity (thus neglecting what Brown et al. [2013] and other consumer culture theorists might refer to as the 'mythological aspects of consumption')? For instance, if the authentic tends to be associated with more positive connotations in western (e.g., rustic, charming) than non-western (e.g., dirty, pastiche) market contexts, it would seem that brand authenticity is an ethnocentric concept whereby authentication in fact could have severe negative outcomes by instituting ideals and

harmful stereotypes in which some of its connotations are viewed as inferior to others (Simmons, 2014; cf. Lehman et al., 2014). However, these perspectives remain largely missing in extant literature. While the first twenty-five years of research on brand authenticity have focused on positive attributions of brand authenticity following the *characteristics that distinguish the 'real thing' from the fake* research stream, it might be time to consider its potentially harmful side effects for consumer well-being and on society. For instance, taking the growing need for consumer researchers to take 'intersectionality' (i.e., the interactivity of social identity structures such as race, class and gender) into consideration, it will be important for the *legitimizing function of authenticity* research stream to highlight the 'systemic and structuring influences of market and social systems that is not necessarily felt or experienced by consumers in their daily lives, and therefore not necessarily discursively expressed' (Askegaard & Linnet, 2011, p. 381), striving towards a more diverse research agenda and inclusive conception of brand authenticity.

DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

The data that support the findings of this study are available from the corresponding author upon reasonable request.

ORCID

Jonatan Södergren  <https://orcid.org/0000-0003-2775-8148>

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AUTHOR BIOGRAPHY

Jonatan Södergren is a doctoral candidate in marketing and business administration at Stockholm University where he is also part of the Gender Academy network. He is an Emerald Literati Awards 2020 winner and his work has previously been presented at the Advances in Consumer Research (ACR) conference. His current research interests include cultural branding, marketplace diversity and ideological aspects of consumption. He thanks the editor, the four anonymous reviewers, and Prof. Sten Söderman for their encouragement and helpful comments on earlier versions of this paper

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